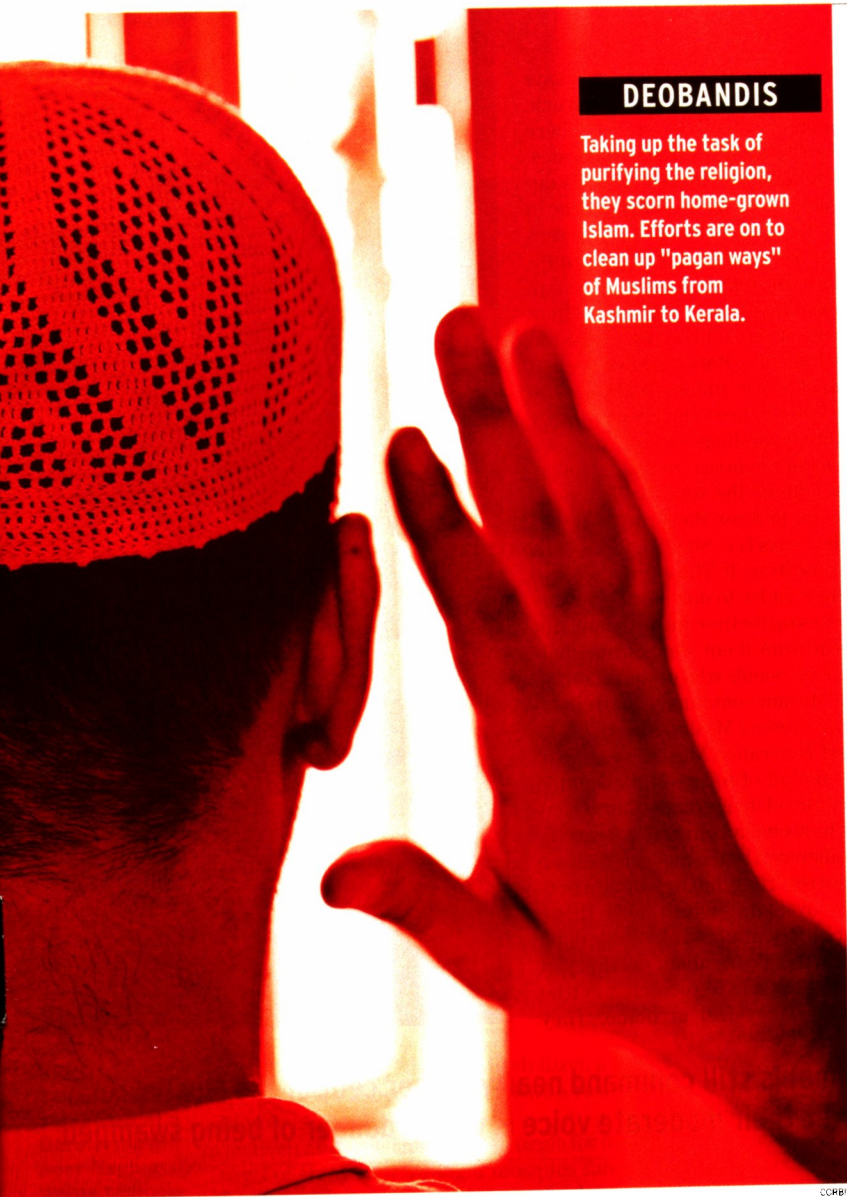




DEOBANDIS

Taking up the task of purifying the religion, they scorn home-grown Islam. Efforts are on to clean up "pagan ways" of Muslims from Kashmir to Kerala.

Prophet as a messenger, to be respected but not revered. Deobandis and their missionary wing, the Tablighi Jamaat—distinguished by their long white tunics, turbans and flowing beards—call for a pan-Islamic identity unencumbered by nation or region.

They are in sharp contrast to the Barelvi school to which over two-thirds of India's 15 crore Muslims subscribe to and who follow the Islam enriched by its contact with fertile local cultures, revere the Prophet and revel in Sufi traditions like dargah visit, music and mysticism. The struggle is almost as old as their origin—both schools sprang from Uttar Pradesh towns, Deoband and Bareilly, in the 19th century. Interestingly, the differences between the Deoband-Tablighi Jamaat and Ahle Hadis schools on one hand and the Barelvi school on the other are deep. Deep enough to often result in physical fights. The Barelvis have a group called Rifai Committee whose only job is to counter the radical propaganda of the Deobandis regarding Islamic tenets. The attacks on Barelvi school's followers in Ajmer Sharif, Hyderabad and Malegaon were believed to have been organised by ultra Wahhabi groups which follow strong Deobandi or Ahle Hadis tenets.

"The terror that is being inflicted in India is not Islamic terror, but Wahhabi terror," says

diploma in mechanical engineering and a masters degree in journalism and mass communications. But he also headed the ultra-extremist SIMI, dedicated to the jihadi ideals of the Taliban.

Nagori's organisation had trained and indoctrinated youth—doctors, engineers and web designers—for assassinations and planting bombs. The youths were nabbed before they could execute their macabre plans. All of them subscribed to the hardline Wahhabi ideology of the Deoband school which practices a rigid, puritanical version of Islam. They loathe what they view as contamination of the faith by Sufi practices and regard the

Mohammed Hamid, a government servant in Nagpur who runs a moderate Islamic organisation IMAN (Indian Muslim Association—Noori) which fights Deobandi fundamentalism. Except for the Mumbai bomb blasts of 1993, carried out in revenge for the communal riots in the aftermath of the Babri Masjid demolition, Barelvis have not been involved in any terror attacks. Whereas a majority of terror groups like the Jaish-e-Mohammed, HCU, Lashkar-e-Toiba and Harkat ul-Ansar owe allegiance to the three sub-groups of Wahhabism in India.

"Wahhabis should explain as to why almost all